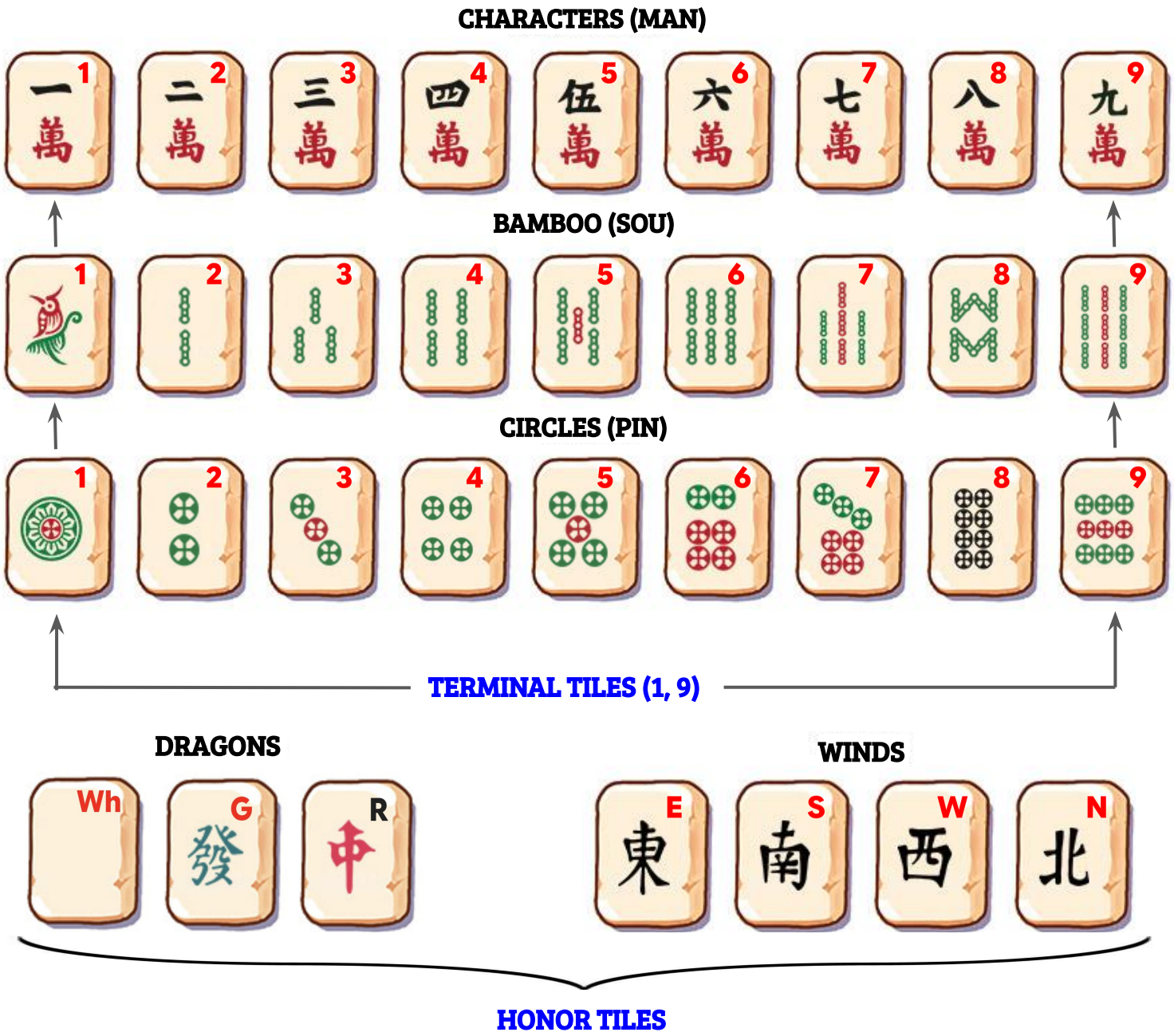
Mahjong Tiles Reference



A Guide for Learning and Playing Japanese Mahjong: Mahjong Tiles and Winning Hands © 2026 Christopher Yee (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0) For full attributions, third-party content details, and licensing information, see the companion PDF: Back Matter

The Tiles of a Japanese Mahjong Set

A Japanese mahjong set consists of 34 unique tiles with four copies of each, for a total of 136 tiles. The tiles of a mahjong set are categorized into different groups.

There are three Number Tile suits, in which the tiles are numbered from one to nine:

- Characters (Man)
- Circles (Pin)
- Bamboo (Sou)

A specific number tile can be referred to as the 6 of characters or the 9 of circles, for example. Another way to refer to these tiles using Japanese terminology is 6-man or 9-pin. Multiple number tiles can be designated as the 234 of bamboo, for instance, or the equally valid 234-sou.

Note that the 1 of bamboo is traditionally decorated with a bird, the design of which may vary across mahjong sets.

The 1s and 9s of the number tiles (1-man/9-man, 1-pin/9-pin, 1-sou/9-sou) are called terminal tiles, as they sit at the ends of the numbered sequence.

The Number Tiles are distinct from the Honor Tiles, which include the Dragon Tiles and the Wind Tiles.

There are three dragon tiles: White dragon, Green dragon, and Red dragon.

There are four wind tiles: East wind, South wind, West wind, and North wind.

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Note that the design of the White dragon tile varies across mahjong sets. It is generally either blank or marked with a rectangular border (shown right).

Mahjong sets may also contain additional tiles such as flower, season, or joker tiles, which are not used in Japanese mahjong.

Japanese mahjong sets often include red fives. Red fives are special tiles found in many Japanese mahjong sets in which one 5 in each suit (circles, bamboo, characters) is painted fully red (shown right). Red fives function as normal fives, except they provide bonus points if included in a winning hand.

Note: There may be further stylistic differences for certain tiles depending on your mahjong set. In particular, the West wind and North wind tiles are sometimes written in slightly different calligraphic styles, even though they represent the same character.

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A Winning Hand

Four Sets and One Pair

Mahjong is played with tiles rather than cards. Instead of a hand of cards, players are given a hand of tiles.

In a game of Riichi mahjong, players start with a hand of 13 random tiles. During the game, players take turns drawing and discarding tiles in an effort to form specific tile patterns that qualify as winning hands.

In Riichi mahjong, a standard winning hand is made up of four sets and one pair.

A set can be one of the following:

- sequence (three consecutive tiles), e.g.

- triplet (three identical tiles), e.g.

- quadruplet (four identical tiles), e.g.

A pair is simply two identical tiles, e.g.

In order for a hand to win, it needs to have four of those sets in any combination — for example, three sequences and one triplet, or four triplets, or two sequences and two triplets — along with one pair.

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Let’s take a look at an example. Suppose you have the following 13-tile starting hand:

Let’s see what it has. It contains:

- a triplet (333-man)
- a sequence (456-pin)
- another sequence (789-sou)
- another triplet (three White dragon tiles)
- one remaining tile (1-sou)

So your hand has four sets — two triplets and two sequences — plus one remaining tile.

But how do you win? Your hand needs four sets <u>and a pair</u> to win.

During a game, players draw a tile on their turn and then discard a tile from their hand. When it is your turn, if you can draw another copy of 1-sou, then you can win. Additionally, if an opponent discards a copy of 1-sou on their turn, then you can declare a win on their discard.

Let’s examine a final example. Suppose you have the following 13-tile starting hand:

This hand has a triplet (333-man), a sequence (789-sou), another triplet (three White dragon tiles), and a pair (11-sou).

So your hand has three sets — two triplets and a sequence — and a pair. It also has two remaining tiles (45-pin).

In this case, your hand has three sets and a pair, and is waiting to complete its fourth set. How can it win?

The fourth set can be completed by either 3-pin or 6-pin, so if you draw either of those tiles — or if an opponent discards one — you can win.

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Summary

In a real game of mahjong, you will generally not be dealt such organized and ready-made starting hands, but will instead need to build sets and pairs in your hand through careful planning of draws and discards. However, the goal remains the same: to complete four sets and a pair.

In summary, if a player completes a hand with four sets and one pair, they are allowed to declare a win.

(This is a simplification, but nearly all winning hands in Riichi mahjong follow this basic four-sets-and-a-pair structure. We will revisit this topic later.)

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A Winning Hand—Revisited

Yaku

In the previous section, it was stated that a winning hand consists of four sets and a pair. However, in Riichi mahjong, a hand must also contain at least one yaku, which is a special scoring element required to declare a win.

The *List of Yaku* packet contains a full list of the yaku used in Riichi mahjong, organized by a scoring unit called han.

As long as a hand has four sets and a pair and contains a yaku, it is eligible to win. Examine the hand below:

As we look at the hand, we see that it has four sets and one pair. In addition, this hand also has a yaku. According to pg. 2 of the List of Yaku packet, a triplet of dragon tiles (White, Green, or Red) counts as a yaku. This hand has a triplet of the White dragon tiles, so it has a yaku.

In other words, this hand:

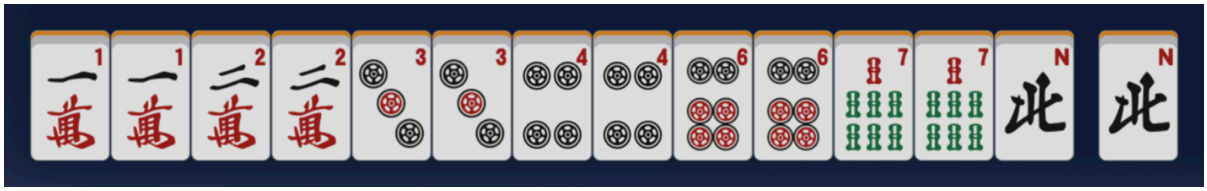
- Has four sets and a pair, and
- Satisfies the minimum yaku requirement to win

This is one example of a complete winning hand.

Yaku are numerous and varied, and learning them requires patience and practice. Therefore, our approach will be to learn yaku gradually, starting with the most fundamental ones.

Seven Pairs

We should first note, however, that in Riichi mahjong, there is an exception that allows a hand to win without the usual four-sets-and-a-pair structure. This exception has its own unique pattern and corresponding yaku. A hand is allowed to win if it contains seven distinct pairs:



This unique hand is called Seven Pairs, and the yaku it satisfies is called the Seven Pairs yaku.

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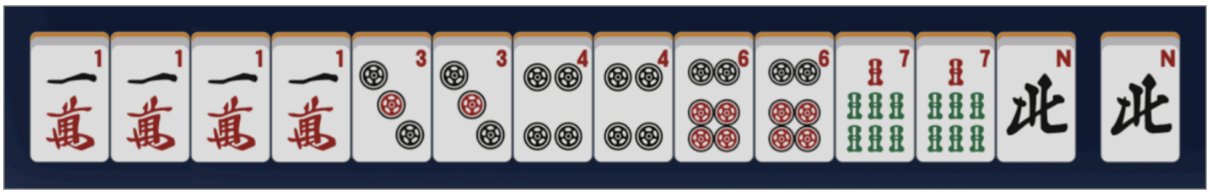
Note that all seven pairs must be different from one another in a Seven Pairs hand. For example, the following hand would not satisfy the Seven Pairs yaku:



Thirteen Orphans

There is one final exceptional way a hand can win in Riichi mahjong. A hand is allowed to win if it contains one of each of the 13 different terminal and honor tiles (that is, 1-man, 9-man, 1-pin, 9-pin, 1-sou, 9-sou, each of the four wind tiles, and each of the three dragon tiles), plus one additional tile that matches any of them:

This remarkable hand is called Thirteen Orphans, and the yaku it satisfies is called the Thirteen Orphans yakuman, one of the rarest and highest-scoring hands in Riichi mahjong.

Summary

In summary, a winning hand in Riichi mahjong must be:

1. A hand with four sets and a pair, plus at least one yaku
2. A Seven Pairs hand
3. A Thirteen Orphans hand

These are the three types of hands that allow a player to declare a win in Riichi mahjong.

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